

East Meets West In L.A. !

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Having lived in Kolkata for the greater part of my life, I see no reasons why I wouldn't carry glimpses of my hometown in my optical sockets! My myopic vision corroborates this visual allegiance to things nearly corresponding to my roots. In this piece, I would like to acknowledge two demographically distinct cities, connected uncannily; for the Angelenos and Kolkatans alike, this might come as a finding of some sort. Let me begin with the cosmopolitan appeal of this city. Los Angeles exudes an aura few others in the league can match. This mecca of entertainment has got all the trappings of a dream that lures us only in celluloid. From the sunny beaches of Malibu to the swanky Downtown skyscrapers, the far-reaching landscape beckons all and sundry. "Oh, East is East, and West is West, and never the twain shall meet" myth got busted on a recent visit to a house party. The famous Kolkata *adda* got translated into a magical evening of fun, food, music, and endless banter. Amidst the buzz as you lay your hands on a dish of *ilish*, you know where the story begins! And storytelling has always been the forte of a true blue Kolkatan.

If Durga Pujo is any indication of the undying spirit of Kolkata and its maddening festive overtures, one has to take a peek into the growing Bengali community in Los Angeles, which unfailingly produces the biggest Bengali spectacle every year in sheer style. With a cultural angle thrown in, the weekend long bonanza doesn't remain just that, but allows the west to witness and absorb the underpinnings of eastern values and ideologies, thus becoming a melting pot of cross-cultural ethos. "Bajlo tomar aalor benu" and the rhythmic *dhaak* beats conjure up images of a land left behind, but not forgotten. Likewise, when Santa Claus comes to town and calls for a celebration, it is no less grand in its splendor, and this fusion wipes out the slightest migratory syndrome. Decking up those pine trees or dining with a roasted turkey is no longer a foreign ritual. It is as inherent as the idea of *ashtami anjali*. Instantly, flashes of Maidan and the Victoria Memorial come blinking as happy-go-lucky Bengalis trot around basking in the Christmas glow.

I knew about Barnes and Noble and its enormous reading potential much before I found myself ensconced in one of its couches (which sometimes induces afternoon siesta surreptitiously), glossing over



books you wish you had written! It gives one a sense of déjà vu; the Oxford Bookstore in Kolkata reflects a similar ambience, one that tickles the intellectual mind while giving way to wander off in the world of reams of prints! The Cha Bar there and the Starbucks here are just two sides of the same coin. Spotting an Amitav Ghosh or a Jhumpa Lahiri in the fiction section is definitely a thrill. Of course,

books are beyond boundaries.

The 3rd street brings me closer to home every time I find myself straddling the length and breadth of it. The restaurants and the shops lined up are so reminiscent of Park Street (Kolkata), which I have breathed for so long as I have shuffled through the heaving traffic there. Without a second thought, the breathing was unmistakably regular, thanks to my professional calling! A Starbucks might well be missing in good old Park Street, but not a hot creamy cappuccino or a caramel Mocha, which the café joints so deliciously brew and serve! Let me not get into the cuisine variety here and there, they complement each other like a well matched couple!

Another striking note of commonality is the plethora of yoga and meditation centers making a profound impact on people in both cities. This ancient practice, though no stranger to the east, has managed to crawl its way through the western psyche, and its spiraling rise has not stopped ever since a certain monk from India electrified the World Parliament of Religions in Chicago in 1893. Decades before Swami Vivekananda's arrival here, however, the yoga teachings have been percolating in the western milieu with many influential writers like Ralph Waldo Emerson and Henri Thoreau, referring to the teachings of Bhagavad Gita and eastern scriptures.

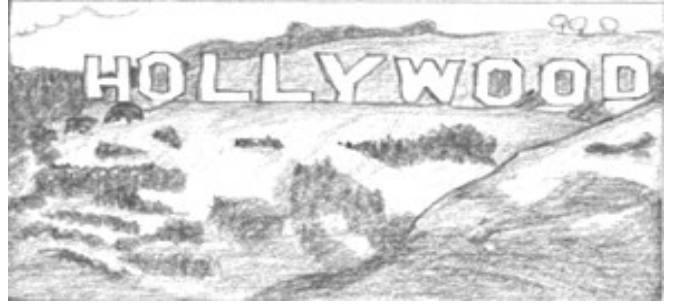
It was the season of Christmas when I first took a round of The Grove, a swanky shopping mall in the heart of the city. Earlier, my mom and I had taken numerous trips around New Market like every Bengali worth his salt might have done in the Bengal metropolis. The two marketplaces buzz in the same tune with a definite eye on style and fashion. While foreigners find the ethnic stuff exhibited in New Market stores exotic, the brands and designs here attract the Kolkata fashion aficionado and, quite expectedly, you see them flaunting a label or two. Sunbathed afternoons are perfect for window shopping as well as for licking a syrupy strawberry gooey ice cream with a sinister grin! After all, basic instincts are cross-cultural!

Just as living in Kolkata doesn't mean that every time you escalate down the Mahanayak Uttam Kumar metro you would find a bevy of Tollywood beauties, so as in Los Angeles. One might take a hike around the Hollywood sign, but catching a glimpse of star tantrums, well... a tough proposition. It took one Ray and an Oscar to fuse the admiration each had for the other, and since then movie makers on both sides of the world have a sizeable audience who are open to powerful, meaningful cinema. Cinema, which just doesn't tie itself to parochialism, rather peddles newer and bolder themes, bearing a global resonance. The Bengali film industry is in the Renaissance phase, if you can call it that. With technology as a catalyst, creative content and experimental treatment is a winning combination on either side. When the story does the talking, language takes a backseat!

What Ralphs is to Los Angeles, Spencer's is to Kolkata! Although grocery and kitchen necessities are relatively a new domain for me, with frequent visits the mart has become a playground, and I frolic around like an adventurer, weighing apples, oranges, broccoli, mushrooms like a veteran grocery shopper! With every pack of milk and cereal I pick up, I am transported back to our dining hall in Kolkata, where my father slurps up the last drip of the white liquid and flakes-filled bowl every morning with a

passion now seen in his son-in-law! Well, milk is thicker than blood in some families!

When it comes to shopping, Kolkata Forum was a quick haunt. So it's only but natural that I will miss the glitzy and flashy mall. Just when I thought I will have to put a leash on my shopping urges, I was introduced to Beverly Center and voila, I got my shopping paraphernalia for all seasons. Retail therapy works best, just forget the rest!



If I have to do an image transfer from Kolkata, I would bring the Prinsep Ghat route, which bears a faint resemblance (only if you generously stretch your imagination) with the Pacific Coast Highway (PCH). Like the beach cafes, the Scoop and the road stalls near Prinsep Ghat are a few of the best attractions which offer passers-by a refreshing treat. Scoop might score high in romance on a breezy spring evening when the Ganges makes those fine ripples, but that does not take away the beauty of the sand, surf, mountains, and speedy track en route PCH. Life is all about these little journeys.

The stretch of road which makes me nostalgic is Santa Monica Boulevard. It reminds me of Red Road in Kolkata, where Jatayu's crumbling green ambassador tires roll with a smoothness not uncommon here! Roads that keep you awake and allow you to feel the sweeping speed of life, stopping only when dreams are realized. For the poet, "miles to go, before I sleep."

My parting shot is for 386, S. Burnside Avenue. It is the place my husband retreats for a hot cup of coffee and conversations at the end of the day. If it was not for him, I would not have known how it is like to feel "at home" in a foreign land. Yes, it is where our home is, the nest where East meets West.

